

Urine Color Guide

What common color changes may mean and when they need medical attention



Urine usually becomes darker as it becomes more concentrated, but color is not a diagnosis.

Normal urine is usually clear to pale yellow. Its color changes with hydration, foods, vitamins, medicines, and some health conditions. Color alone cannot diagnose a disease, but a persistent or unexplained change can be a useful reason to contact a healthcare professional.

Appearance	Possible explanations	Suggested action
Clear to pale yellow	Typical hydration; very clear urine can follow high fluid intake	Use thirst and medical advice to guide intake
Dark yellow or amber	Concentrated urine, often from dehydration	Drink fluids if appropriate; seek help if severe or persistent
Orange	Dehydration, vitamins or medicines; sometimes liver or bile problems	Review medicines and seek advice if unexplained
Pink, red or smoky brown	Foods or medicines, but possibly blood in urine	Contact a healthcare professional, even if painless
Brown or tea-colored	Severe dehydration, liver problems, blood or muscle breakdown	Prompt medical assessment is appropriate
Cloudy or milky	Crystals, cells, discharge or possible infection	Seek advice if persistent or accompanied by symptoms
Blue or green	Food dyes, medicines or rarely infection	Seek advice if unexplained or persistent

Why urine is yellow

A pigment called urobilin contributes to urine's yellow color. When less water is present, the urine becomes more concentrated and usually appears darker. Hydration is therefore a common explanation for day-to-day variation, but not every dark color is caused by dehydration.

Foods, vitamins, and medicines

Beets, blackberries, food coloring, B-complex vitamins, and several medicines can alter urine color. A useful review asks what was eaten and which prescription, over-the-counter, or supplemental products were taken before the change appeared. Do not stop a prescribed medicine without professional advice.

When color may signal a problem

Visible blood can make urine pink, red, or brown and may occur with infection, stones, injury, kidney disease, prostate conditions, or urinary tract cancers. Dark brown urine may also be associated with liver disease or muscle breakdown. Cloudiness accompanied by burning, urgency, fever, or lower abdominal pain can occur with a urinary tract infection.

When to get help

Contact a healthcare professional for visible blood, an unexplained color change that does not resolve, clear dark-brown urine, or pink, red, or smoky-brown urine not explained by food or medicine. Seek urgent care when the change occurs with severe pain, inability to urinate, fever and chills, yellow skin or eyes, confusion, marked weakness, or reduced urine output.

A clinician may use urinalysis, urine culture, blood tests, imaging, or other evaluation depending on the symptoms and medical history.

Sources

1. MedlinePlus. Urine - abnormal color. <https://medlineplus.gov/ency/article/003139.htm>
2. NIDDK. Prevention of Bladder Control Problems and Bladder Health. <https://www.niddk.nih.gov/health-information/urologic-diseases/bladder-control-problems/prevention>
3. NIDDK. Hematuria (Blood in the Urine). <https://www.niddk.nih.gov/health-information/urologic-diseases/hematuria-blood-urine>

This article provides general educational information and does not replace individualized medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment.